Tuesdays with Morrie

By Mitch Albom

The last class of my old professor's life took place once a week in his house, by a window in the study where he could watch a small hibiscus plant shed its pink leaves.

The class met on Tuesdays. The subject was The Meaning of Life. No books were required, yet many topics were covered, including love, work, community, family, aging, forgiveness, and, finally, death. It was taught from experience.

The last class of my old professor's life had only one student. I was the student.

INTRODUCTION

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His death sentence came in the summer of 1994. Morrie had amyotrophic lateral sclerosis (ALS), Lou

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Gehrig's disease - There was no known cure.

"How did I get it?" Morrie asked. Nobody knew.
"Is it terminal?"
Yes.
"So I'm going to die?"
Yes, you are, the doctor said. I'm very sorry.

ALS is like a lit candle: it melts your nerves and leaves your body a pile of wax. Often, it begins with the legs and works its way up. You lose control of your thigh muscles, so that you cannot support yourself standing. You lose control of your trunk muscles, so that you cannot sit up straight. By the end, you are breathing through a tube in a hole in your throat, while your soul, perfectly awake, is imprisoned inside a limp husk, perhaps able to blink, or cluck a tongue, a man frozen inside his own flesh. This takes no more than five years from the day you contract the disease. Morrie's doctors guessed he had two years left. Morrie knew it was less.

But my old professor had made a profound decision: He would not wither. He would not be ashamed

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of dying. Instead, he would make death his final project, the center point of his days. Since everyone was going to die, he could be of great value, right? He could be research. A human textbook.

"Study me in my slow and patient demise. Watch what happens to me. Learn with me." Morrie would walk that final bridge between life and death, and narrate the trip.

We Talk about Death

"Mitch," he said softly, "you know that I'm dying." I knew. "All right, then." Morrie swallowed the pills, put down the paper cup, inhaled deeply, then let it out. "Shall I tell you what it's like?"

What it's like? To die?

"Yes," he said. Although I was unaware of it, our last class had just begun.

"Dying," Morrie suddenly said, "is only one thing to be sad over, Mitch. Living unhappily is something else. So many of the people who come to visit me are unhappy."

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Why?

"Well, for one thing, the culture we have does not make people feel good about themselves. We're teaching the wrong things. And you have to be strong enough to say if the culture doesn't work, don't buy it. Create your own. Most people can't do it. They're more unhappy than me—even in my current condition. "I may be dying, but I am surrounded by loving, caring souls. How many people can say that?"

I was astonished by his complete lack of self-pity. Morrie, who could no longer dance, swim, bathe, or walk; Morrie, who could no longer answer his own door, dry himself after a shower, or even roll over in bed. How could he be so accepting?

We Talk About the World

"It's hard to explain, Mitch. Now that I'm suffering, I feel closer to people who suffer than I ever did before. The other night, on TV, I saw people in Bosnia running across the street, getting fired upon, killed, innocent victims . . . and I just started to cry. I

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feel their anguish as if it were my own. I don't know any of these people. But—how can I put this?—I'm almost . . . drawn to them." His eyes got moist, and I tried to change the subject, but he dabbed his face and waved me off.

Amazing , I thought. I worked in the news business. I covered stories where people died. I interviewed grieving family members. I even attended the funerals. I never cried. Morrie, for the suffering of people half a world away, was weeping. Is this what comes at the end, I wondered? Maybe death is the great equalizer, the one big thing that can finally make strangers shed a tear for one another.

I leaned over to give him a hug. And then, although it is not really like me, I kissed him on the cheek. I felt his weakened hands on my arms, the thin stubble of his whiskers brushing my face.

"So you'll come back next Tuesday?" he whispered.

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We Talk About Feeling Sorry for Yourself

I asked Morrie if he felt sorry for himself.

"Sometimes, in the mornings," he said. "That's when I mourn. I feel around my body, I move my fingers and my hands—whatever I can still move—and I mourn what I've lost. I mourn the slow, insidious way in which I'm dying. But then I stop mourning. I concentrate on all the good things still in my life. On the people who are coming to see me. On the stories I'm going to hear. On you—if it's Tuesday. Because we're Tuesday people."

I grinned. Tuesday people. I thought about all the people I knew who spent many of their waking hours feeling sorry for themselves. How useful it would be to put a daily limit on self-pity. Just a few tearful minutes, then on with the day. And if Morrie could do it, with such a horrible disease . . .

"It's only horrible if you see it that way," Morrie said. "It's horrible to watch my body slowly wilt away to nothing. But it's also wonderful because of all the time I get to say good-bye." He smiled. "Not everyone is so lucky."

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I studied him in his chair, unable to stand, to wash, to pull on his pants. Lucky? Did he really say lucky?

We Talk About Regrets

I wondered what regrets he had once he knew his death was imminent. Would he have done much differently? Selfishly, I wondered if I were in his shoes, would I be consumed with sad thoughts of all that I had missed? Would I regret the secrets I had kept hidden?

"Mitch," he said, "the culture doesn't encourage you to think about such things until you're about to die. We're so wrapped up with egotistical things, career, family, having enough money, meeting the mortgage, getting a new car, fixing the radiator when it breaks—we're involved in trillions of little acts just to keep going. So we don't get into the habit of standing back and looking at our lives and saying, Is this all? Is this all I want? Is something missing?" He paused.

"You need someone to probe you in that direction. It won't just happen automatically."

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I knew what he was saying. We all need teachers in our lives. And mine was sitting in front of me. And I figured if I was to be the student, then I would be as good a student as I could be.

That day, I made a small list on a yellow legal pad, issues and questions that we all grapple with:

Death
Fear
Aging
Greed
Marriage
Family
Society
Forgiveness
A meaningful life

We Talk About Fear

The small horrors of [Morrie's] illness were growing, and when I finally sat down [again] with him, he was coughing more than usual, a dry, dusty cough that shook his chest and made his head jerk forward. After one violent surge, he stopped, closed his eyes, and took a breath.

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"What I'm doing now," he continued, his eyes still closed, "is detaching myself from the experience. And this is important—not just for someone like me, who is dying, but for someone like you, who is perfectly healthy. Learn to detach. Detachment doesn't mean you don't let the experience penetrate you. On the contrary, you let it penetrate you fully. That's how you are able to leave it."

I'm lost.

"Take any emotion—love for a woman, or grief for a loved one, or what I'm going through, fear and pain from a deadly illness. If you hold back on the emotions—if you don't allow yourself to go all the way through them—you can never get to being detached, you're too busy being afraid. You're afraid of the pain, you're afraid of the grief. You're afraid of the vulnerability that loving entails. But by throwing yourself into these emotions, by allowing yourself to dive in, all the way, over your head even, you experience them fully and completely. You know what pain is. You know what love is. You know what grief is. And only then can you say, 'All

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right. I have experienced that emotion. I recognize that emotion. Now I need to detach from that emotion for a moment.'"

Morrie stopped and looked me over; perhaps to make sure I was getting this right. "I know you think this is just about dying," he said, "but when you learn how to die, you learn how to live."

I thought about how often this was needed in everyday life. How we feel lonely, sometimes to the point of tears, but we don't let those tears come because we are not supposed to cry. Or how we feel a surge of love for a partner but we don't say anything because we're frozen with the fear of what those words might do to the relationship.

Morrie's approach was exactly the opposite. Turn on the faucet. Wash yourself with the emotion. It won't hurt you. It will only help. If you let the fear inside, if you pull it on like a familiar shirt, then you can say to yourself, "All right, it's just fear, I don't have to let

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it control me. I see it for what it is. I know that there are other emotions in the world, and I'm going to experience them as well."

"Detach," Morrie said again.

We Talk about Society

Morrie believed in the inherent good of people. But he also saw what they could become. "People are only mean when they're threatened," he said later that day, "and that's what our culture does. That's what our economy does. Even people who have jobs in our economy are threatened, because they worry about losing them. And when you get threatened, you start looking out only for yourself. You start making money a god. It is all part of this culture." He exhaled. "Which is why I don't buy into it."

"You must build your own subculture. Here's what I mean," Morrie said. "I don't mean you disregard every rule of your community. I don't go around naked, for example. I don't run through red lights. The little things, I can obey. But the big things—how we think, what we

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value—those you must choose yourself. You can't let anyone—or any society determine those for you.

"Take my condition. The things I am supposed to be embarrassed about now—not being able to walk, not being able to wipe [myself], waking up some mornings wanting to cry—there is nothing innately embarrassing or shaming about them. It's the same for women not being thin enough, or men not being rich enough. It's just what our culture would have you believe. Don't believe it."

He continued. "The problem, Mitch, is that we don't believe we are as much alike as we are. Whites and blacks, Catholics and Protestants, men and women. If we saw each other as more alike, we might be very eager to join in one big human family in this world, and to care about that family the way we care about our own. "But believe me, when you are dying, you see it is true. We all have the same beginning—birth—and we all have the same end—death. So how different can we be?"

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"Invest in the human family. Invest in people. Build a little community of those you love and who love you."

He squeezed my hand gently. He smiled. "In the beginning of life, when we are infants, we need others to survive, right? And at the end of life, when you get like me, you need others to survive, right?" His voice dropped to a whisper. "But here's the secret: in between, we need others as well."

Graduation

Morrie died on a Saturday morning. He had fallen into a coma two days after our final visit, and the doctor said he could go at any moment. Instead, he hung on, through a tough afternoon, through a dark night. Finally, on the fourth of November, when those he loved had left the room just for a moment—to grab coffee in the kitchen, the first time none of them were with him since the coma began—Morrie stopped breathing. And he was gone.

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Have you ever really had a teacher? One who saw you as a raw but precious thing, a jewel that, with wisdom, could be polished to a proud shine? If you are lucky enough to find your way to such teachers, you will always find your way back.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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